

healthy dose of realism and common sense. And I know, the last person you want giving you advice is your folks. Fine. Uncle Kevin's here. You'd better listen to what I have to say.

So you've graduated from university or trade school. Congratulations! The world is your oyster, right? You heard about that one guy in your class who sold his start-up for \$2 million a week before graduation—now it's your time to shine. After all, according to you, you deserve a windfall of cash, a closetful of Armani and some really nice dating prospects, right?

Wake up and smell the slow-brewed coffee, my young friend: few waltz into that kind of fortune right out of university. If you're lucky, you will eventually find work that is meaningful and fulfilling, but it's not instant. We've all got to pay our dues.

The 20s are a battlefield. Never before will you have been under so much pressure to spend large amounts of money on things you don't really need—the perfect apartment, the perfect suit. It's like everyone in the world is screaming, “You're finally an adult! Now spend like one!” You've got a legitimate adult job and a nice little paycheck. At first, you're careful. But then you go out for drinks with people from work, and then a couple of nice dinners, and you don't want to look like the cheapskate, so you charge it all to your credit card. Suddenly, you've got a big balance that you can't pay off with your flimsy paycheck, especially while you're bleeding cash on rent for the studio apartment of your dreams. And you really do need a new designer briefcase for work. And look! There's a sale on drapes—wouldn't those look nice in your apartment?

Do you see the problem? All the little expenditures add up—and you may also be paying off your student loans. It's no wonder that most men and women accrue thousands of dollars of debt before their 30th birthday. All this is assuming you can even find a job. Recently, a Statistics Canada report found that of the 1.4 million Canadians who are currently unemployed, almost a third are young people between the ages of 15 and 24. As more young people enter the workforce, there are fewer and fewer jobs available for them. In 2013, the Canadian labor force lost a whopping 39,400 jobs in July 2013 alone. This puts an even greater strain on your finances.